

STRIKES REACH OUTSKIRTS OF TEHRAN

US expands attacks, Iran calls Hormuz a ‘red line’, retaliates

Associated Press
Dubai, July 16

THE UNITED States intensified its strikes on Iran on Thursday, hitting targets farther north and firing into a ship the US accused of trying to break its naval blockade on the Islamic Republic. Iran retaliated by launching missiles and drones at US allies in the region, and warned its attacks may escalate.

Iranian officials say US strikes have killed more than 35 people and wounded over 300 others. For the first time in this latest round of violence, strikes also reached into areas around Iran's capital, Tehran, showing a widening set of targets for the Americans.

Col Ebrahim Zolfaghari, a spokesperson for the Iranian military, threatened that Iran could launch widespread attacks on “all the infrastructure in the region” if the US acts on President Donald Trump's repeated warnings that America could hit Iranian bridges and power plants. “Under no circumstances and in no way will we allow America, as a foreign and extra-regional country, to interfere in the Strait of Hormuz,” he added. “This is Iran's invincible red line.”

The US strikes early Thursday hit around Tehran, state media reported. It also reported that American attacks targeted Semnan province, home to Iran's ballistic missile production and space program. Iranian media also reported strikes Thursday around the provinces of Hamedan, Hormozgan, Khuzestan, Lorestan, Markazi, and Sistan and Baluchestan, as well as on Iran's Qeshm island, near



A man waves an Iranian flag beneath a billboard reading, 'Who is D next One?' an apparent reference to US President Donald Trump, in downtown Tehran on Thursday. REUTERS

Be ready to ‘shut’ Red Sea gateway if US hits power network: Iran to Houthis

Dubai: Iran has asked Yemen's Houthi movement to stand ready to close the Red Sea oil route if the United States strikes Iranian power infrastructure, three sources told *Reuters* on Thursday, posing a potent new threat to global energy supplies.

The idea has been discussed within the Islamic Republic's leadership, and the message has been conveyed to Iran's Houthi allies, two senior Iranian sources and a regional

source familiar with the matter said, speaking on condition of anonymity.

The sources said the Houthis had been informed recently of Tehran's request, which has not been previously reported. They did not give further details on how it had been conveyed or whether it was after US President Donald Trump's threat to attack Iranian power infrastructure on Tuesday. **REUTERS**

the Strait of Hormuz.

On Wednesday, the US resumed striking Iran during daylight, further showing the increasing tempo of the attacks. An attack on Greater Tunb Island targeted Iranian defense and missile sites, Central Command said. Greater Tunb Island is one of three small rocky

islands that sit at the confluence of the Persian Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz and have become a garrison for Iran.

The US military also said it disabled a Curacao-flagged oil tanker as it sailed toward Iran's main oil export terminal, firing a missile after the ship “ignored multiple warnings.”

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 17~07~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

EXPRESS special

Vessels to and from India among top applicants for Hormuz passage

Three-week data from June 17 shows 40% of vessels seeking to cross Hormuz were to or from India and China

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 16

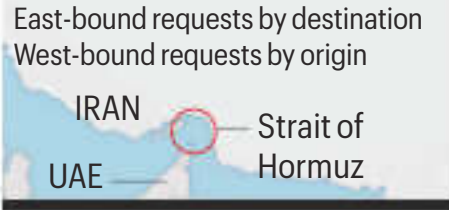
MERCHANT VESSELS to and from India were among the top applicants for passage through the Iran-recommended routes to cross the Strait of Hormuz in the three weeks following the June 17 US-Iran peace MoU, as per Iranian data.

According to Persian Gulf Strait Authority (PGSA), set up by Iran to regulate the flow of maritime traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, over 200 non-Iranian vessels coordinated with it to receive passage permits and insurance coverage during the three week period.

Among the transit requests to exit the Persian Gulf received by the Islamic Republic's PGSA

Transit requests

Origin/destination	West-bound	East-bound
India	21%	20%
China	19%	21%
Other Asia	20%	29%
Intra-region	24%	22%
Other World	16%	8%



SOURCE: PERSIAN GULF STRAIT AUTHORITY

set up recently by Tehran, those bound for India had a 20% share, second only to China's 21%.

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Two dead in Puri Rath Yatra

Devotees surround an ambulance during the annual Rath Yatra in Odisha's Puri, Thursday. At least two persons died and several others sustained injuries following a crowd surge. AP

REPORT, PAGE 14

US latest on immigration: Shrink visa duration for students, media

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 16

IN A move that is expected to impact a large number of US-bound Indians, the Donald Trump administration on Thursday moved to tighten the visa duration for foreign students, journalists and cultural exchange visitors.

According to a US government notice, the new final rule from the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) creates a fixed time period for F visas for

international students, J visas that allow visitors on cultural exchange programmes to work in the US, and I visas for members of the media. Currently, these visas are available for the duration of the programme or employment in the US.

Under the new regulations, the student and exchange visa periods would be no longer than four years. The visa for journalists — which currently can last years — would be for up

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

New roadblock
US President Donald Trump has kicked off a wide-ranging immigration crackdown since taking office — revoking student visas over ideological views and stripping legal status from migrants. The latest move will create new hurdles for students, exchange workers and journalists.

— WITH REUTERS INPUTS
FROM WASHINGTON DC

Hormuz passage

There are reports that transits have grown slightly over the past three days, but most pertain to Iran-linked vessels. Since mid-June, vessel movements through the strait had risen meaningfully, even crossing 90 on June 24, with the average being between 40 and 50 on most days in the three weeks that followed the MoU, industry data shows. But these were still lower than the pre-war levels of up to 140 daily transits.

EXPRESS special

Delhi's winter pollution plan: For last-mile delivery in city, cargo from diesel trucks to be transferred to EVs

Five logistics hubs around NCR to serve as freight interchange points

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, July 16

THOUSANDS OF diesel trucks are stopped at Delhi's borders every winter when pollution curbs under the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) kick in, prohibiting their entry. Now, a proposed network of five multimodal logistics hubs around the National Capital Region (NCR) could allow their cargo to continue its journey.

These hubs would serve as freight interchange points outside Delhi, where long-haul diesel trucks from neighbouring states would transfer their trailers or cargo to electric trucks for the final leg into the capital, *The Indian Express* has learnt. The plan aims to reduce freight emissions while improving logistics efficiency.

Proposed under the Centre's National Highways for EV (NHEV), a PPP initiative, they are planned at Sonipat, Faridabad, Ghaziabad, Greater Noida

and Gurgaon. In the initial phase, it aims to shift nearly half of the long-haul freight entering Delhi to the hub-and-spoke model. Abhijeet Sinha, Project Director at NHEV told *The Indian Express*, "The long-term objective is for diesel trucks to stop at the city's edge, with only zero-emission freight vehicles entering Delhi."

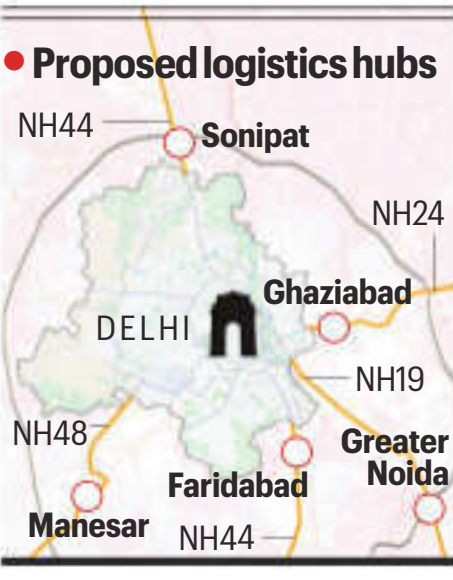
Officials said the phased approach addresses a recurring problem logistics operators face during severe air pollution episodes. Under Stage IV of GRAP, entry of diesel medium and heavy goods vehicles is restricted, except for those carrying essential commodities or meeting specified exemptions. This often leaves loaded trucks stranded outside the city and disrupts supply chains. The proposal comes amid growing concern over emissions from interstate freight traffic. A June study by IIT Delhi, TERI and the Air Pollution Action Group (APAG) found that nearly 17,000

heavy-duty trucks enter Delhi every day, making them one of the Capital's biggest yet least-addressed sources of transport pollution. While accounting for only a fraction of vehicles on the road, these trucks contribute about 23% of transport-sector Particulate Matter (PM) 2.5 emissions, with their impact rising sharply at night when most are allowed to enter the city.

Freight interchange

Each hub is proposed to be spread over around six to eight acres, including a core operational area of about five acres and additional space for truck parking. The first phase would involve land acquisition, construction of logistics infrastructure, and installation of charging stations for electric commercial vehicles, with operations expected to begin within the next 16-18 months. According to project officials, land parcels are currently being identified and earmarked for the facilities.

Officials associated with the project said the challenge is to secure the periphery and ensure no polluting truck enters Delhi through arterial roads. To



fix this, electronic enforcement systems are also being planned along these routes to ensure

Site assessment for hub being carried out at Hapur on Delhi-Lucknow highway. CREDIT: NHEV

that trucks required to use the freight hubs do not bypass them and enter Delhi directly.

Unlike conventional transshipment facilities, the proposed model is centred on a trailer-exchange system. This means a diesel tractor unit arriving at a logistics hub would detach its trailer, which would then be coupled to an electric tractor for onward movement into Delhi. Since trailers follow standard dimensions and

coupling systems, they can be hauled by tractor units from different manufacturers, such as Ashok Leyland or Tata Motors, without opening the container, officials said.

In cases where the consignee requires cargo to be segregated or delivered in smaller loads, the container can be opened at the logistics hub. These would be segregated and sorted according to destination and loaded onto smaller electric commercial vehicles, such as five-or-six-tonne trucks, for last-mile deliveries, officials said. The project is currently in the planning stage, with officials expecting to submit the proposal to the government in October. This will be followed by a pilot in November to test both the operational and commercial aspects of the model, including trailer interchange, electronic enforcement and the pay-per-use pricing mechanism before wider implementation.

Project documents describe the facilities as integrated freight and energy hubs rather than standalone EV charging stations. Besides supporting trailer interchange and freight

consolidation, the hubs are expected to provide charging infrastructure for electric commercial vehicles, warehousing and logistics support, digital fleet management and other ancillary services.

Site selection is underway along major freight corridors leading to the capital. Earlier this month, officials from the NHEV Greenways project and the National Highways for EV Working Group, along with representatives of logistics company CJ Darcl Logistics Ltd, carried out a site assessment at Hapur on the Delhi-Lucknow highway to evaluate its suitability for a future multimodal logistics hub serving freight movement into the NCR.

Impact on pollution

As per the June study, 16,900 heavy-duty trucks enter Delhi each day, releasing an estimated 52 kg of PM 2.5, three tonnes of nitrogen oxides (NOx) and 2.5 tonnes of carbon monoxide (CO) daily. Older pre-BIS VI trucks, despite accounting for just 38 per cent of truck entries, contribute 62 per cent of PM 2.5 emissions from inter-

state freight, besides 87% of NOx and 95% of CO emissions.

Their impact is far greater during the night, when nearly three-fourths of interstate trucks enter the city because of entry restrictions. Between 10 pm and 7 am, heavy-duty trucks account for nearly 61 per cent of transport-related PM 2.5 emissions, with pollution concentrations further aggravated by lower atmospheric mixing heights during these hours.

The report had recommended establishing Urban Consolidation Centres at the city's periphery where freight from long-haul trucks can be transferred to cleaner vehicles such as electric or CNG trucks for last-mile distribution. It had also recommended deploying automated Weigh-in-Motion payload sensors along with AI-enabled ANPR cameras at toll plazas to improve enforcement, identify overloaded vehicles and ensure compliance with freight regulations. According to project officials, the proposed multimodal hubs are intended to complement such measures by creating an alternative freight ecosystem.

DRIVE FOR 14-YEAR-OLD GIRLS

New target for Health Dept: 1.49 lakh HPV vaccinations in 100 days

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, July 16

MORE THAN four months after India launched its nationwide Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccination programme for 14-year-old girls, Delhi has administered roughly 13,500 vaccine doses, prompting the state government to launch a renewed push in schools with an ambitious target of vaccinating 1.49 lakh girls over the next 100 days, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Officials said the fresh target comes after the Health department reviewed the campaign's progress following its initial 90 days and concluded that deeper engagement with schools would be critical to accelerating coverage. "We decided to re-approach the Education department for its full cooperation at the school level. We are giving this initiative a renewed push since schools have now opened up after summer vacation. We aim to achieve 1.49 lakh vaccinations in 100 days," a Health department official said.

India rolled out its national HPV vaccination programme on February 28 to protect 14-year-old girls against cervical cancer, aiming to vaccinate nearly 1.15 crore girls annually.

Cervical cancer is the second most common cancer among women in India and remains one of the country's leading causes of cancer-related deaths among women.

While Delhi's coverage has steadily risen from around 11,000 doses reported in May to approximately 13,500 now, officials acknowledged that prog-

• HPV VACCINATION NUMBERS

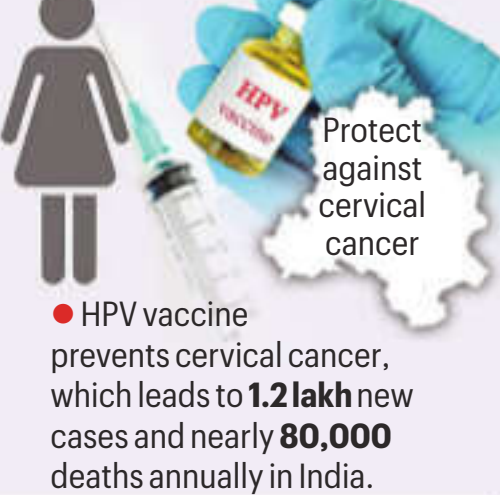
13,500 GIRLS

vaccinated in Delhi since the drive began on February 28.

Target: 1.49 lakh vaccinations across Delhi in next 100 days.

● Campaign intensified in schools after reopening following summer vacation.

● Doctors, principals and DDEs mobilised to boost awareness and parental consent.



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ress has been slower than anticipated, largely because schools were occupied with examinations before closing for the summer vacation.

"We had first written to the Education department in March seeking its cooperation in spreading awareness about the drive. But soon, examinations started in schools and then summer vacation began, creating a gap of nearly over a month. That is why the progress slowed," the official said.

With schools reopening, the Health department has once again reached out to Education authorities, holding both virtual and in-person meetings with deputy directors of education (DDEs) across districts as well as school principals.

"We are personally and virtually interacting with each DDE in every zone and with principals to push the programme. Doctors from our department are visiting schools on the ground to spread awareness about HPV and the vaccine," the official said.

The department has also intensified its communication campaign to counter vaccine hesitancy, which officials continue to identify as one of the programme's biggest challenges. "We are circulating videos explaining the benefits of the vaccine and myth-busting misinformation. Many people have fears, so we are sharing videos of senior doctors explaining why people should not believe rumours," the official said.

The campaign will focus heavily on government schools, with health officials expecting classroom-based awareness sessions, counselling of parents and coordinated efforts between teachers and healthcare workers to improve vaccine uptake over the next three months.

Officials are also using testimonials from women who received HPV vaccines years ago to reassure parents. "We are showing videos of women and their success stories. Many who received the vaccine in 2009 have now given birth and are healthy," the official said.

EXPRESS special

Hydrogen Train rolls out today; leak detectors, auto shutdown, real-time monitoring on track

Express News Service
Chandigarh, July 16

INDIA'S FIRST hydrogen-powered train, to be flagged off by Prime Minister Narendra Modi from Haryana's Jind railway station Friday, has multiple layers of safety features that can detect gas leak, heat, and smoke, and an automatic shut-off system that will cut off the hydrogen supply, without waiting for manual reaction, in case anything unusual is found.

"The train is fitted with devices that continuously watch for hydrogen leaks, unusual heat, flames or smoke, so any problem is caught within seconds. On top of this, non-stop ventilation keeps air moving through the train at all times, so that even if a tiny amount of hydrogen were to leak, it gets safely carried away and diluted in the open air instead of collecting anywhere," a statement issued by the Ministry of Railways read. "There is also an automatic shut-off system. If anything unusual is detected, it can automatically cut off the hydrogen supply on its own, without waiting for a person to react."

With the launch of the 10-coach train, which will operate between Jind and Sonipat section of Northern Railway, India will join a select group of nations that has adopted the clean technology. "India becomes one of



X/ @RAILMININDIA

The train has 10 coaches with a capacity of 2,600 passengers

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the select group of nations that have such trains. This will go a long way in ensuring that India adopts clean technology in the railway sector," Modi said.

Unlike electric trains that draw power from overhead wires, the Hydrogen Fuel Cell Trainset generates electricity on board through a Proton Exchange Membrane (PEM) fuel cell. Hydrogen stored in cylinders reacts with oxygen from the atmosphere to produce electricity for the traction motors, with water vapour and heat as the only direct by-products.

"In a sense, the train carries its own source of power, but instead of burning traditional fuels, generates electricity using oxygen from the atmosphere," as per the ministry's statement. As electricity is generated on board through clean-hydrogen technology, the train represents the greenest form of

rail propulsion, powering the future of sustainable mobility.

Given hydrogen's highly flammable nature, the train is equipped with multiple layers of safety systems. The loco pilot's cabin has been designed to keep the person safe, with a special mode that allows the train to be moved to safety in an emergency and a screen that shows the loco pilot the real health of the whole system at all times. The dedicated hydrogen storage, compression and dispensing facility established at Jind too has similar safety features, including leak and flame detectors, automatic shutdown systems, fire alarms and water spray arrangements. At the facility, water is split into hydrogen and oxygen through electrolysis and is then stored safely in dedicated storage tanks.

The train has an operational speed of 75 kmph and a design speed of 110 kmph on the 89-km

Jind-Sonipat route. The train has 10 coaches with a capacity of around 2,600 passengers, demonstrating the scalability of hydrogen-powered rail transport for high-capacity passenger operations on non-electrified or difficult-to-electrify routes.



Ahead of the big deal, strike a careful balance

FOLLOWING THE US Trade Representative's proposal to levy tariffs on 60 countries under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, 1974, the government has introduced a new section in the foreign trade policy regarding forced labour. India is not the only country to do so — Indonesia, Canada, Cambodia and Peru have responded with similar commitments after the USTR's proposed tariffs. Simultaneously, India has sought a review of the USTR's proposed tariffs of 12.5 per cent, alluding to inconsistencies in its examination. The country's tariff challenges don't end here. US President Donald Trump's tariff policy is, as of now, operationalised through Section 122 of the Trade Act. However, the 10 per cent universal rate currently levied can only be imposed for at most 150 days (without Congressional approval), which end on July 24. Trump is trying to reinforce the tariff wall through other pathways. Alongside the investigation into forced labour, USTR is examining the issue of "structural excess capacity and production in manufacturing sectors" in economies, including India. The outcome of that investigation, and if it attracts additional tariffs, is yet to be released.

This, however, is not the only contentious area — energy is another lever. A few days ago, a group of US senators unveiled a new version of the Russia sanctions Bill that proposes to levy tariffs of up to 100 per cent on the top five buyers of Russian oil and natural gas — China, India, Slovakia, Hungary and Azerbaijan. Imports from Russia account for a significant share of India's energy basket. Here, too, New Delhi has taken US concerns on board — PSUs have signed a deal to import 10 per cent of LPG requirements from the US.

In the recent past, the Indian government has pushed through trade deals with countries such as the UK and Australia, as well as the EU. A deal with the US now — the largest economy in the world — will go a long way in reducing the uncertainty that has marred relations between the countries, while expanding trade. The upside for both countries is significant. On its part, the White House will likely continue to exert pressure on India in order to extract maximum concessions. As Delhi moves ahead to expand its market and protect its interests, it will have to carefully navigate its way, mindful of an unpredictable White House.

No one did it, it happens: War to exam scandals, pollution to crumbling cities

YESTERDAY, WITHIN minutes, I encountered two statements that seemed to capture the core pathology of contemporary politics: The return of malfeasance or evil without agents. Sonam Wangchuk, on the 15th day of his fast, was outlining the core of his thinking behind asking for the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan: It was to fix accountability and agency for an exam fiasco that affects hundreds of thousands of lives. In a completely different context, I encountered this reflection by one of the sharpest contemporary philosophers, Raymond Geuss, in an essay, "Without Causes," published in *New Left Review*. The essay discusses an interview Hillary Clinton gave on Gaza. There is one striking line in the essay, "When Clinton must refer to conditions on the (Gaza) Strip her sentences break down and suddenly lack a grammatical subject: 'Reconstruction frozen. Investment absent. Civilians trapped in dependency and despair, with reportedly up to 1,000 killed since the ceasefire'. We are not told who killed them."

The two examples illustrate the same phenomenon. Across an astonishing range of policy challenges, from war to pollution, exam scandals to crumbling cities, we encounter seemingly causeless phenomena; sentences without subjects. At the international level, our Prime Minister sets the tone. "This is not an era of war," he intones with sagacity, without ever naming who the actors are who start the wars. You might think this is diplomatic finesse. But it turns out to be a full-blooded technique of ruling. If there are no agents behind the action, no one needs to

be held accountable. Your success is not stopping the war, condemning aggression, or upholding the law. Your success is that you can immobilise the need for responsibility altogether without appearing immoral.

Now, just think how useful this strategy is domestically. Sentences without grammatical subjects or in the passive voice can easily make passive citizens. Exam leak. Happens. Cities flooding. Happens. Himalayas crumbling. Happens. Stampedes. Happen. Air Pollution. Happens. Just as we know this is not an era of war, but we don't name who starts it, we also know this is not an era of crumbling cities, polluted air and rivers, disenfranchisement and corruption, and any other evil you can mention. But no one makes it happen.

The beauty of the passive voice is that the government can join the citizens in a common language and a common objective. These days, it has become the norm for government ministers, civil servants, or recently retired decision-makers to write about their departments with impressive expertise. They will outline lofty goals, even share citizens' concerns. But the one thing missing in all that writing is the fixing of accountability. You will read hundreds of op-eds on air pollution, including by policymakers. But no one will name or shame, as it were. For example, no one will pointedly say who decided to relax pollution norms for coal-fired power plants and why. Who makes the decisions to give clearances to build roads and buildings in ecologically sensitive zones? I was recently at a meet-



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

Wangchuk's insistence on a resignation is not simply about one minister or one examination. It is a defence of the proposition that democratic politics requires a grammatical subject

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> ing where there was eloquent holding forth on "ease of doing business, especially for MSMEs". But not one policymaker could actually name and explain why particular regulations were put in place or even who put them. If you ask a pointed question, all policy, all events, all decisions suddenly become anonymised through invoking "The Bureaucracy" or "The System" or "The Court" or "Norms". As if policy is made by abstractions, if even made at all.

Now you might demur and say, "Isn't this an age of personalised politics, not events without subjects? Don't we attribute all evils to leaders, Vladimir Putin or Narendra Modi, or Donald Trump?" But the cult of personality is one more way in which accountability gets evaded; it's like holding God responsible. When God is responsible, no one is. The personality is meant to disguise the myriad of actions that go into the making of catastrophes. Yes, the person at the top has to shoulder the blame for setting the norms. But that is also a convenient alibi for not fixing individual responsibility. "Modi" and "Trump" become a vast impersonal force that governs everything, so we can stop interrogating actual chains of decisions.

Now, speaking in euphemisms, without a subject, allows a certain civility. Perhaps in the international sphere, it allows for diplomacy. A culture of individual naming and shaming can also be misused and be cruel. There might be some truth to these concerns. But at the present conjuncture, this really has become a technology for creating a passive world in which everything,

from genocide to environmental destruction, happens. Even well-meaning critiques of policy fall into this trap. The crisis of public policy in India is not the crisis of ideas. Most things that require attention are not rocket science. It is the crisis of accountability: Who will name who actually takes decisions and hold them responsible? Everyone has this knowledge, but we choose to anonymise it. Perhaps this is being done with mass participation: It suits all of us not to blame any specific agents, since that also absolves us of any responsibility. It gives us a kind of freedom. It allows us to defer to power without appearing to do so.

Perhaps this is why Wangchuk's demand is important. His insistence on a resignation is not simply about one minister or one examination. It is a defence of the proposition that democratic politics requires a grammatical subject. Before institutions can be repaired, we must acknowledge who specifically broke them. If you want to stop war, you have to name and shame those who start them.

Raymond Geuss may be onto something profound. In his telling, it is not that Hillary Clinton was denying the truth. What she was making disappear was the subject of the sentence. The artful form of modern governance is to acknowledge the truth and yet evade responsibility. Once a society loses the habit of asking, "Who did this?", it also loses the capacity to ask: "Who should answer for it?" There is no democracy without a grammatical subject.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

NATO's transformation opens possibilities for India



SAKTI PRASAD SRICHANDAN

THE 2026 NATO Summit held in Ankara a few days ago confirmed that the alliance is entering a new era of strategic transformation rather than strategic decline. Ukraine remains central, but NATO's ambitions now go much further. It is preparing for a world shaped by long-term rivalry, technological competition and unstable supply chains. This shift matters for India.

The first message from Ankara is clear: Russia will remain NATO's principal security challenge for years to come. Even if the war in Ukraine ends, NATO has decided that deterrence must become permanent. The second message is that Europe is being asked to do much more for its own security. The US remains indispensable, but Washington is increasingly unwilling to carry the burden alone. The third is perhaps the most important. Modern wars are won not only on the battlefield but also in factories and laboratories. The Ukraine war exposed serious weaknesses in ammunition production, missile manufacturing and defence supply chains. Technology is completing this transformation. AI, cybersecurity, quantum computing, autonomous systems and space capabilities are today's strategic priorities.

India is not a NATO member. But its security environment is increasingly shaped by decisions taken far beyond its neighbourhood. Europe's growing investment in defence opens new possibilities for India's defence industry. Indian firms can become partners in supply chains that are being diversified away from dependence on a few countries. India's ambition to become a manufacturing hub fits well with Europe's search for trusted partners. If New Delhi moves quickly, defence cooperation can become part of a broader technology and industrial partnership. Further, NATO's strategic outlook increasingly links European security with developments in the Indo-Pacific, maritime security, critical technologies and supply chains. This reflects a broader reality: Security today is interconnected. For India, this creates both opportunities and dilemmas. The opportunity lies in expanding cooperation with European countries on maritime security, cyber resilience, critical technologies and defence innovation. The dilemma is Russia, which remains one of India's major defence partners and an important energy supplier. At the same time, India has deepened strategic ties with the US and Europe. As NATO's confrontation with Moscow grows more entrenched, balancing these relationships will become more difficult.

This is why India's policy of strategic autonomy remains relevant. It should avoid the temptation to see NATO only through the prism of the Ukraine war. NATO is evolving into an organisation where defence, technology, industry and economic resilience are increasingly interconnected. That evolution will shape global standards, defence innovation and strategic partnerships. Instead of asking whether NATO is relevant to India, policymakers should ask: How can India benefit from Europe's security transformation while preserving its strategic autonomy? Done well, India can gain economic and security advantages from the transatlantic rearmament wave. Handled poorly, the same wave could push New Delhi into costly dependencies and strategic choices that weaken the autonomy it has worked hard to preserve.

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The dilemma is Russia, which remains one of India's major defence partners and an important energy supplier. At the same time, India has deepened strategic ties with the US and Europe



The cybersecurity lesson in e-rickshaws

nerabilities can disrupt operations or disable critical equipment. That is a significant problem: Such systems support power grids, telecom tower systems, warehouses, ports, industrial automation, and defence platforms.

India has robust institutions for cybersecurity guidance, including the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) and the National Critical Information Infrastructure Protection Centre (NCIIPC) for critical infrastructure. However, a coherent strategy for connected battery systems is missing. CERT-In has expanded its focus to guidance on secure software development, coordinated vulnerability disclosure, Software Bills of Materials (SBOMs), and security requirements for original equipment manufacturers against AI-assisted vulnerabilities. But the guidelines are not binding and offer limited guidance on cybersecurity requirements for connected battery products.

The NCIIPC protects sectors such as power, transport and telecommunications.

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Grid-scale Battery Energy Storage Systems may fall within their remit when deployed as part of designated critical infrastructure. However, connected battery systems in EVs, commercial storage deployments and consumer BMS remain outside its jurisdiction.

Sectoral regulators such as the Central Electricity Authority have sought to address battery risks through fragmented lenses, focussing on organisational cybersecurity or functional safety. The Department of Telecommunications and MeitY have introduced security assurance mechanisms for connected devices. But these mandatory regimes do not specify Bluetooth-enabled BMS and the apps used to manage them.

Modern battery systems comprise hardware and software sourced from around the world. Consequently, the security of the battery depends on the integrity of its digital supply chain as much as its physical one.

Global regulations reflect the focus on evaluating digital supply chains. The Secure

Software Development Framework and SBOM initiatives in the US, or the Cyber Resilience Act and the Digital Battery Passport in the EU, audit software provenance, firmware integrity, vulnerability management and lifecycle traceability.

India can draw on these principles: CERT-In guidance on secure software development, Software and Hardware Bills of Materials, vulnerability disclosure, and cybersecurity audits can be incorporated into battery standards. These will allow a battery assembled in India to incorporate imported BMS, firmware, or software update infrastructure developed abroad. Imported hardware can be allowed after rigorous testing and verification of secure software development practices. These will ultimately move the conversation from the origin of technology to its demonstrable trustworthiness.

*The writers are policy professionals
at Koan Advisory Group*

Bulldozers will have to roll when encroachers thwart law, says SC

Observation amid hearing of case on state authorities flouting the apex court's 2024 order

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 16

OBSERVING THAT bulldozers will have to roll “when a comfortable corruption between municipal authorities and illegal encroachers thwarts the rule of law”, the Supreme Court on Thursday refused to consider a batch of pleas alleging widespread contempt of the apex court’s 2024 judgment against “bulldozer justice”, and asked aggrieved parties to move their respective High Courts.

A three-judge bench presided over by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant heard petitioners who sought contempt of court proceedings against

various state authorities for allegedly flouting the SC’s November 13, 2024 judgment, which held that using bulldozers to demolish homes of people merely because they are accused in some cases is contrary to the rule of law.

The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, pointed out to the petitioners that their pleas involved disputed questions of fact which will have to be adjudicated by someone.

Agreeing, Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati said the petitions are from across the country, and a factual inquiry will be required in each case.

The CJI said, “And the facts are bound to vary from case to case. The court might be required to summon the record and examine it.”

He said the SC had already laid down the broad principles, and it is now for the High Courts and courts below them to ensure compliance.

As Senior Advocates Sanjay Hegde, C U Singh and Huzefa

Amadi pressed the bench to decide the case in the light of the November 13 judgment instead of leaving it to the High Courts, Justice Bagchi said “the back-drop of the judgement” “in fact really shocked the conscience of this court, because there was an infraction, not of municipal laws, but the foundation of presumption of innocence, where there was pick and choose of certain individuals accused of crime by going against their properties...”

Justice Bagchi stressed, “Yes, bulldozers need to be used when the rule of law is thwarted by a comfortable corruption between municipal authorities and illegal encroachers. But then we need also to protect that under the guise of implementing law, there should not be a terrorisation of individuals, or special treatment. It actually runs against one of the basic tenets that can a person claim negative equality...”

“No judgment can be looked at in isolation of the factual situation,” Justice Bag-
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

chi said.

Hegde said his client Ganesh Gupta had a fruit juice stall on which a bulldozer was used. Justice Bagchi said, “It can be used... Question is whether this person had an authorisation or the process of law was followed or not.”

Hegde said in his case, there was a TV anchor who sat on a bulldozer and came there. The CJI said all these facts will have to be looked at by someone.

Ahmadi said in his matter, which involved the demolition of a mosque, there was an egregious breach of the court’s order.

“The High Court gave me protection and said you will give time to file reply etc and till then don’t pass a final order. Even before a final order was served upon me, they came and demolished and then I had to move for contempt before this court and your lordships gave me order of status quo.”

He said, “So far as I am concerned, there was no action taken by authorities from 1999 to 2024. This action only got

initiated on account of a letter which was issued by a local politician where he said how can you have Asia’s largest mosque in this particular state... So, therefore, this is not one of those standard cases, it is one of pick and choose... In my case, there was also no allegation of encroachment on public property...”

Senior Advocate Singh argued that if the SC doesn’t stand up for its own judgment, then who will?

“Who said we will not? We will stand for our judgments. We will direct the HC to ensure compliance with our judgment,” said the CJI.

Justice Bagchi said what the bench intended to convey is that the judgment “cannot be read as a statute. Judgment has to be read in the context...”, more so when there is a caveat attached to it that the directions will not be attracted if there is unauthorised structure in any public place such as road, street, footpath, abutting railway line or any river body or water bodies.

ISRO moves to halt exodus of staff from critical projects

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, July 16

AFTER A spate of exits from crucial projects - including human spaceflight programme Gaganyaan - rattled the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), the body has decided to not accept requests for voluntary retirement or resignations of senior scientific staff associated with important missions without a review.

In 2020, ISRO had authorised the heads of its various centres and units across the country to accept resignations or requests for voluntary retirements of Group A scientific or technical staff of up to a certain rank. In a fresh order dated July 14, ISRO has said that such requests would now have to be referred to the department (Department of Space) for action.

“Any such requests received from scientific/technical personnel, even of and below the rank of scientist/engineer-SG, may be sent to the Department with clear recommendations of the directors of centres/heads of units for final decision,” it said.

Private sector perks

The space sector was thrown open to private parties in the last decade. This created new opportunities with better pay and perks for scientists and engineers in the field. Staff at almost all private space companies in India comprise former ISRO employees.

Multiple sources told *The Indian Express* that the UR Rao Satellite Centre (URSC) in Bengaluru and the Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre (VSSC) in Thiruvananthapuram, two of the largest and most prestigious centres of ISRO, witnessed the bulk of the exodus. This,

they said, prompted the space department to issue the order.

While VSSC focuses on research and development of rockets and launch systems, URSC is involved in design and development of satellites. The knowledge and experience of scientists working with these bodies is the most sought after in the Indian industry.

“ISRO management, the work culture and environment of a government sector is no longer considered attractive and is not being appreciated by the younger employees. Then, there have been instances when the employees have felt that the management has favoured some sections of employees with promotions, while ignoring others. It is a fact. A lot of employees at ISRO are not very happy working in this kind of a set-up,” an ISRO official said on condition of anonymity. The latest order has attracted criticism, said one official, as it has amounted to curtailment of powers of ISRO’s centre directors who were very high-ranking officials.

“Any government employee, including those at ISRO, is entitled to apply for voluntary retirement after 15 years of service, and this request has to be processed within three months. So, the issuance of this order, dated July 14, is itself questionable,” said the official.

In Delhi, Science and Technology Minister Jitendra Singh, also the minister-in-charge of Space, sought to play down the issue of attrition in ISRO. He said the ISRO memo in question was just an administrative order, and said it was not unusual for a large workforce like that of ISRO to see some level of attrition. “Some people decide to go, but others also join,” he said.

BIMSTEC meet in Delhi: Security chiefs vow to combat terror

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 16

NATIONAL SECURITY chiefs of BIMSTEC countries on Thursday vowed to jointly combat regional security challenges and endorsed new guiding principles to streamline maritime law enforcement coordination.

This is significant since BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) comprises India, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Nepal and Bhutan, and all of them have stakes in the developments in the Indian Ocean.

The meeting held in New Delhi was hosted by National Security Advisor Ajit Doval. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the national security advisors and heads of delegations discussed practical and result-oriented solutions to combat terrorism and organised crime, and to ensure security in the cyber, maritime and energy domains.

It said they also deliberated on boosting connectivity, facilitating efficient disaster management.

“They adopted guidelines for the maritime component of humanitarian assistance and disaster relief. These will help

BIMSTEC member states to undertake relief operations in the region,” the MEA said.

“They also endorsed a set of guiding principles on the conduct of maritime law enforcement agencies during interactions at sea,” it said.

The MEA said these principles are expected to outline reference points for increasing predictability and promoting safety during maritime engagements among member states.

“As BIMSTEC approaches its 30th anniversary next year, the National Security Advisors/ Heads of Delegations reiterated their resolve to further enhance collaboration and knowledge sharing towards strengthening regional security, building resilience, and enhancing institutional capacities to address diverse security threats,” it said.

Doval underscored the need for closer regional cooperation to tackle evolving security challenges, saying the current global landscape marked by conflicts, geopolitical uncertainties and disruptions requires BIMSTEC member states to work together and take “decisive actions” for their mutual benefit.

The NSA said BIMSTEC have built strong cooperation across security sectors and made significant progress in countering threats.

EXPRESS special

Drones reduce time and cost of TB diagnosis: Study

Cost for diagnosis went down from Rs 9,451 to Rs 91, shows ICMR study

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 16

DRONES CAN be very effective in reducing the time and cost of tuberculosis diagnosis, found a study conducted by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) in Telangana.

In the areas where drones were used to carry patient samples to centres with molecular diagnostics, the average time to receive a TB diagnosis reduced from 16.6 days to 6.9 days. Importantly, the cost for this diagnosis went down from Rs 9,451 to just Rs 91, according to the study.

This comes at a time when the government is looking towards various innovations, including several AI tools, to catch up. India missed the deadline it set for itself for eliminating TB by 2025. The global deadline for ending TB is set for 2030. “Affordable and timely access to diagnosis remains central to India’s TB elimination efforts.

This study demonstrates how technology can help bridge geographical barriers and reduce the burden on patients, particularly those living in remote areas.

“The evidence generated through the i-DRONE initiative will help inform future public health innovations while complementing existing healthcare delivery systems,” said Dr Rajiv Bahl, director general, ICMR.

A hub-and-spoke drone network was established between 60 sub-centre, 11 primary health centres and four TB units in Telangana — Alair, Bhongir, Ramannapet, and Choutuppal — where the samples from these centres



Drones can transform TB diagnosis in rural India by speeding up sample transport, reducing costs and easing travel burdens for patients, found the study.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mlj/Mzg1 were being tested. The aim was to see whether it can actually improve the efficiency of TB diagnosis in remote and rural areas, especially hilly regions where poor road infrastructure, unpredictable weather, and long distances to the laboratories hamper timely diagnosis.

Around 840 people who had been diagnosed at these four centres were enrolled for the study, with 206 individuals receiving their diagnosis before the i-drone initiative and 634 afterwards.

Usually, the patients would have to travel from their respective villages to the TB units to get the test if they were thought to have the infection. Before the i-DRONE initiative, patients would have to travel anywhere between 10 and 30 kilometres by road with often limited transport facility.

Afterwards, they could go to their nearest sub-centre or primary health centre — which do not have the molecular diagnostic tests but can collect sample — and give their sputum that could be transported using the drones.

“Patients reported travel difficulties, loss of daily wages, and stigma as reasons for delaying care,” the study said. Almost all of the participants were poor patients, reporting a

monthly income of less than Rs 5,000.

Two types of drones were used for the initiative — an 11.5 kg drone that could carry a 2-kg payload and a 24-kg drone that could carry an 8 kg payload. Detailed flight routes were pre-programmed, keeping in mind the terrain, population density, and no-fly zones. Safe take-off and landing sites were also created at these health centres and TB units.

What did the pilot study find?

The study also found that the proportion of persons receiving their diagnosis within a day or two also went up.

The proportion of patients receiving results the same day as the sample is sent increased slightly from 6.3% to 7.4% with the drones, but the number of people receiving the results next day went up sharply from 1.5% to 76.3%.

The study also found that the proportion experiencing delays more than 2 days fell from 92.2% in the pre-drone phase to 16.3% in the drone phase, according to the study. It went on to say that the findings mirror what was also observed in Manipur and Nagaland where similar drones have been successfully used.

Monsoon Session: BJP likely to table 5 new Bills; ‘delimitation package’ not on its agenda

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 16

THE BJP-led NDA government is likely to table five new Bills, including one aimed at making provisions for registration of births and deaths more stringent, in addition to taking up the contentious Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill in the Monsoon Session, which starts Monday.

The agenda for the session does not include the “delimitation package” of which the Nari Shakti Adhiniyam, or women’s reservation Bill, is a significant component. The Bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha after the NDA failed to secure the two-thirds majority required for a Constitutional amendment.

Sources said this “package”, which requires both total and special majority in the House of the People, will need to be tabled and ratified by the Union Cabinet to be put into motion yet again, which could be taken up

during the session. BJP insiders said the matter was likely to come up for discussion at a meeting to be chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh with NDA leaders on Friday.

The FCRA Amendment Bill, which seeks to amend the FCRA (Regulation) Act, 2010, that governs the acceptance and utilisation of foreign contribution and foreign hospitality to “ensure that such inflows do not adversely affect national interest, public order or national security”, was listed for “consideration and passing”. The proposed legislation was tabled March 25.

According to the agenda, the ‘Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025’, which was introduced in the Lok Sabha on December 15, 2025 but later referred to a Joint Committee of both Houses, will also return to centre stage with the 31-member committee’s report scheduled to be presented and considered during the session.

A Bill seeking to further

amend Section 13(3) of the Registration of Births and Deaths Act, 1969 (as amended in 2023), in order to make provisions for registration “more stringent”, and the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026, which is intended at replacing an existing ordinance in this regard, were among the two new significant legislation proposed to be taken up during the session.

The other proposed legislative business includes the Income-Tax (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which aims to “deepen India’s sovereign debt market”, attracting stable global capital inflows and enhance liquidity.

The other Bills likely to be tabled are Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and a Bill which seeks to align the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development Act, 2006 with the “changing MSME landscape” and enhance ease of doing business in the sector.

IMD: Dry conditions to prevail in most parts until month end

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 16

DRY CONDITIONS will prevail over large parts of the country for the remaining days of July, except for the east and north-east regions where rainfall will continue, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Thursday.

“Overall, rainfall activity is likely to be normal to above normal over most parts of east and northeast India and below normal over the remaining parts of the country during July 16-22. Normal rainfall is likely over central India during July 22-29,” the IMD said in its weekly forecast.

The IMD had forecast below-normal rainfall (about 94 per cent of the long period average) over the country during July. At the end of the first half of the month, the country’s rainfall deficit stood at 8 per

cent. With the rainfall having taken a break since July 9 over most parts of the country, the country-wide seasonal deficit has slipped to 24 per cent.

As for most of the remaining days of July, the monsoonal trough - an elongated zone of low pressure areas prominent during this season - would be positioned much to the north of its normal position and remain closer to the Himalayan foothills. Correspondingly, the rainfall over south, central and northwest India expected to remain subdued. Rainfall over central India is likely to pick up towards the last week of July, when this trough would swing back to its normal position, the Met office said.

IMD also said that strong northwesterly winds will be dominant and prevent the inflow of monsoonal winds that cause rainfall.

According to the latest fore-

cast, heavy to very heavy rainfall is likely to occur over Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi and east and western regions of Uttar Pradesh till July 22. Very heavy rain (120-200mm in 24-hours) warning prevails for Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and east Uttar Pradesh during July 19-21.

Likewise, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram and Tripura are bracing for very heavy rainfall which is expected to continue till July 19.

Heatwave conditions will prevail over coastal Andhra Pradesh, Yanam, Rayalaseema, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karikal on July 17. Muggy weather will prevail over Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Telangana, coastal Andhra Pradesh, Yanam and Rayalaseema till July 22.

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SC judge flags Class 9 stress, suggests third language from Class 6

Remarks came after TN raised concerns over the three-language policy during a hearing on Navodaya schools

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 16

THE SUPREME Court said on Friday that the third language should be introduced in Class 6, not Class 9, observing that learning a new language a year before board examinations can be stressful for students.

Presiding over a two-judge bench, Justice B V Nagarathana made the remarks while hearing an appeal by the Tamil Nadu government challenging a Madras High Court direction to facilitate the establishment of Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas (JNVs) in every district of the state. The High Court had held that the state's refusal to permit JNVs curtailed students' right to choose educational institutions and was inconsistent with the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act of 2009.

The bench, also comprising Justice R Mahadevan, counselled the state not to oppose every Central scheme merely because they come from the Centre. “You may have your education system, but don’t prevent the Central government schools. Don’t have this attitude that ‘it is the Union government, why should we accept it,’” Justice Nagarathna said.

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The CBSE's three-language policy has been challenged before the Supreme Court in petitions pending before a bench presided over by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant.

While the three-language policy was not a direct issue in the matter heard on Thursday, the Tamil Nadu Government counsel flagged the state's concerns regarding the policy during the hearing. This invited the comments from the bench.

Justice Nagarathna pointed out that as per the policy, "The state language has to be taught in English has to be taught and any third language. It doesn't say Hindi." The counsel appearing for the petitioner, on whose plea the Madras HC passed its order, said the National Education Policy (NEP) bars the imposition of any language on any state. This prompted Justice Nagarathna to ask, "You don't want Hindi, but if it's Sanskrit, what is the issue?"

When informed that the third language becomes mandatory only from Class 9, Justice Nagarathna said, "That is very bad. The ninth standard is stressful. Why do you introduce a new language in the ninth grade? You introduce it in the sixth."

"Union of India, please don't have a third language in the ninth standard," she said. "CBSE, ICSE, State Board, tenth standard is a board exam. From the end of the eighth standard onwards, the pressure starts... Don't start a new language in 9th. Start it in 6th..."

Fixing the matter for hearing next on August 11, the court noted that discussions between the Centre and the state on the issue are still on and that the question of hearing it on merits would arise only if they fail.

DAYS AFTER ASSAM RIFLES CAMP TARGETED IN SENAPATI DISTRICT

CRPF redraws SOP for Manipur

Lays stress on use of bulletproof vehicles, women personnel in troop movement

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 16

DAYS AFTER a mob attacked an Assam Rifles camp in Senapati district of Manipur, the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has reworked its strategy for troop movement and field deployment in the state.

Sources said the revised instructions place strong emphasis on protected and guarded movement of personnel, both for administrative duties and operational tasks.

Around 100 bulletproof vehicles have been sent to Manipur to strengthen force protection and mobility, officials



Charred remains of a vehicle that was torched by a mob in Manipur's Senapati district, Wednesday. PTI

said. CRPF personnel have been directed to move only in bulletproof vehicles in sensitive areas, said sources.

"Administrative movement, which often involves routine deployment, supply,

coordination and movement between camps or duty points, has also been brought under tighter security protocol. Such movement will now have to be well-guarded and planned in advance," an official said.

As part of the revised strategy, women personnel will be included in troop movement teams, as and when required. This decision was taken in view of recent instances when women protesters took the lead in surrounding security forces during operations or movement, an official said.

ested routes, where convoys are considered vulnerable," the official said.

According to officials, around 320 companies of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs), excluding the Assam Rifles, are currently deployed in Manipur, as part of the Centre's efforts to stabilise the security situation in the state, which has witnessed prolonged ethnic violence.

The CRPF is also working to reduce hostility from Kuki groups with confidence-building measures and careful deployment patterns to prevent further escalation, said officials.

Skyroot to launch Vikram-1 orbital rocket tomorrow

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 16

INDIAN SPACE-TECH startup Skyroot Aerospace will attempt the first orbital launch of its indigenously developed rocket, Vikram-I, on Saturday, July 18, at 11.30 am, from the country's premier spaceport at the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota. The mission, named 'Agastham', meaning 'arrival', marks a milestone for India's private space sector: the nation's first-ever attempt to place a payload into orbit using a completely privately developed launch vehicle.

All necessary airspace and maritime notices have been issued establishing restricted zones during the launch window, according to the company.

ram-1 on the ground. On July 18, we are eager to see how Vikram-1 performs in a real flight environment for the first time," said Pawan Kumar Chandna, co-founder and CEO of the company.

"This is our first test flight, and we will be getting valuable data from it. This will be foundational to Skyroot's aspirations of establishing launch cadence. We are excited to see this through," he added.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>



India's first private orbital rocket, Vikram-1, stands fully stacked at Sriharikota for the upcoming 'Mission Aagaman' test flight.

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diamond art piece called Cos-
mic Bloom from Cosmos Dia-
monds and a micro-art piece.

"This test flight will show us how every technology we have developed over the years performs in real-world conditions. With the in-flight data gathered from this mission, we will return to the shop floor to learn, improve, and build further. This test flight is the first step towards creating a reliable, on-demand launch company for the world from India," said Naga Bharath Daka, co-founder and COO of the company.

Vikram-1 launcher

Named in honour of Dr Vikram Sarabhai, the father of India's space programme, the launcher stands seven storeys tall. It is engineered to deliver small satellites weighing up to

350 kg to Low Earth Orbit (LEO). For this launch, it is targeting a 450 km orbit at a 60-degree inclination.

Alongside Skyroot's Vikram-1, Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO)'s own Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV) and Agnikul's under-development rockets are set to expand India's capability to launch satellites in this region of space. This is significant given the increasing number of companies developing small satellites intended for low Earth orbit, such as the fleets by internet providers Starlink and OneWeb.

So far, two Indian launch vehicle developers, including Skyroot, have demonstrated sub-orbital flights — vehicles that take a satellite to outer space but lack sufficient velocity to put it into orbit.

‘NO CENTRAL SUBSIDY FOR LAND ACQUISITION TO SET UP CHIP PLANTS, STATES EXPECTED TO TAKE LEAD’

Govt not keen to cover land, tech transfer costs in new chip scheme

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 16

UNDER THE next phase of India's ambitious Rs 1.27 lakh crore Semiconductor Mission, the Central government may not offer subsidies to companies arising out of technology transfer costs, with the prevailing thought being that calculating such expenses is complicated, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The Centre may also no longer offer subsidies for land acquisition to set up chip manufacturing plants, as state governments are expected to take the lead on that, a senior government official said.

Under the first iteration of the scheme, there was a provision for the government to cover a portion of technology transfer costs that approved companies may incur, but a senior government official said that it has been removed under India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0. Even though the provision existed under ISM 1.0, such disbursements were not made, it is understood.

“The reason we have de-

cided to not offer subsidies on technology transfer costs is because when we were evaluating proposals under the first leg of the scheme, there was a realisation that such transfer costs are quite opaque. It is almost impossible to reliably calculate the exact amount, so we have made changes accordingly,” the official said, requesting anonymity.

Technology transfers are an important element in companies setting up semiconductor manufacturing operations in India, because many participants may not have access to such technology in-house. For instance, Tata Electronics, which is setting up a chip fabrication plant in Gujarat, is getting the manufacturing technology from Taiwan's PSMC.

These reconsiderations also point to the broader theme of India's shifting priorities under its new chip incentive scheme. The new policy is expected to place greater reliance on subsidising chip design, and the broader ancillary industry.

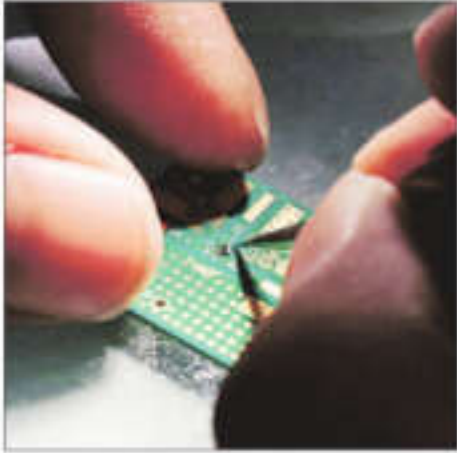
“In terms of our priorities for the new scheme, first would be chip designing, then bringing the broader supply chain

• TECH TRANSFER COSTS

TECH TRANSFERS are an important element in firms setting up semiconductor manufacturing operations in India, because many participants may not have access to such tech in-house

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BUT A senior government official said the provision has been



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Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mliMzgl ecosystem to India, and then subsidising building of new chip manufacturing units,” a second official said.

On Wednesday, the Union Cabinet approved ISM 2.0 with an outlay of Rs 1.27 lakh crore. Under the first scheme, India managed to attract 12 chip making plants, including a fabrication facility being set up by the Tata Group.

The country's foray into semiconductor production and

packaging has been outlined as a strategic move by New Delhi to insert itself into the global chip supply chain and establish the sector to deepen domestic value addition in its electronics sector. Semiconductors — used to power devices from toasters to fighter jets — have become a critical resource amid heightened geopolitical tensions over the last few years.

By 2029, India expects to achieve the capability to design

SPECIFIED NON-FINANCIAL ASSETS

RBI introduces SNFA category, bars banks from selling assets back to defaulters

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 16

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has introduced the concept of Specified Non-Financial Assets (SNFAs) in the event of loan defaults and mandated that disposal of such assets should primarily be through public auctions under SARFAESI Act principles and prohibited resale to the original borrower or related parties.

SNFAs refer primarily to immovable properties that banks acquire when borrowers fail to repay loans. Such assets typically include residential buildings, commercial properties, industrial land or other real estate accepted by banks in settlement of outstanding debt.

The RBI has issued the Third Amendment Directions, 2026 under its Commercial Banks – Resolution of Stressed Assets Directions, 2025. The new regulations establish a comprehensive framework for how banks should acquire, value, manage and dispose of non-financial assets obtained from defaulting borrowers.

According to the new directions, banks may acquire an SNFA only after a borrower's loan has been officially classified as a non-performing asset. The acquisition must involve either full or partial settlement of the bank's outstanding exposure. In cases where only part of the loan is settled through the transfer of property, the remaining debt



Specified non-financial assets are immovable properties that banks acquire when borrowers fail to repay loans. REUTERS

will continue to be treated under restructuring norms, ensuring that banks maintain appropriate provisioning and risk management standards.

The RBI has introduced strict valuation guidelines to prevent overvaluation. Every acquired property must be recorded at the lower of two values — the net book value of the extinguished loan or the distress sale value determined independently by at least two external valuers.

Banking experts believe this conservative valuation method will reduce the possibility of inflated asset values appearing on bank balance sheets while encouraging more realistic financial reporting. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Sourav Anand
New Delhi, July 16

THE POWER ministry has proposed a tougher five-year fuel-economy regime for passenger vehicles from April 1, 2027, tightening fleet-average consumption targets while allowing carmakers to use carbon-neutrality benefits, super credits and a compliance-credit mechanism to meet the new standards.

The draft Corporate Average Fuel Economy-III norms, circulated for stakeholder consultation, will cover M1-category passenger vehicles manufactured or imported for sale in India between 2027-28 and 2031-32. The existing CAFE-II norms are likely to expire on March 31, 2027.

Under the proposed framework, the fuel-consumption target will progressively decline from 3.996 litres per 100 km, equivalent to 94.76 gCO₂ per km, in 2027-28 to 3.3273

litres per 100 km, or 78.90 gCO₂ per km, by 2031-32.

Compliance will be assessed across two blocks, comprising an initial three-year period followed by a second block of two years. The phased tightening is intended to provide automobile manufacturers a predictable regulatory path for developing and deploying more fuel-efficient models.

In a significant change, the ministry has proposed Carbon Neutrality Factors for ethanol, biofuel and compressed biogas for the first time. The mechanism will permit specified reductions in declared tailpipe carbon dioxide emissions before a manufacturer's compliance is assessed.

At the current ethanol-blending level, an 8% Carbon Neutrality Factor has been proposed. For compressed biogas and biofuel, the reduction will be linked to the prevailing actual

blending level.

Manufacturers will also be eligible to claim compliance benefits of up to 9 gCO₂ per km for approved fuel-saving technologies, with the benefit capped at 1 gCO₂ per km for each technology.

The draft provides super credits while calculating fleet-average fuel consumption for battery electric vehicles, range-extended electric vehicles, plug-in hybrids, strong hybrids and flex-fuel vehicles, giving manufacturers additional flexibility to expand cleaner vehicle portfolios. It also proposes a credit-and-debit system similar to the mechanism in the recently circulated draft amendment to the CAFE-II norms.

The proposed regime combines steadily tighter fuel-consumption targets with incentives for alternative fuels, electrified vehicles and fuel-saving technologies. FE

• THE LEAK INCLUDES A 14.3 GB DATASET COMPRISING 18,997 FILES RELATED TO THE KUDANKULAM NUCLEAR POWER PLANT

Kudankulam files on dark web: Inside the alleged data leak

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 16

FOR MORE than a month, a large cache of files purportedly linked to the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant have been available on the dark web.

The data, leaked by ransomware group World Leaks, is purportedly linked to Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group, whose subsidiary, Reliance Infrastructure Ltd, was awarded the Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) contract in 2018 for the plant's non-nuclear common service facilities, known as the Balance of Plant (BoP).

The leaked data, accessed by *The Indian Express*, includes a 14.3 GB dataset comprising 18,997 files related to

the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant. These files are part of a much larger cache of 1.2 terabytes containing over 858,000 files purportedly linked to the Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group.

A search in the leaked dataset using the term “KKNP” — an acronym for the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant — retrieves numerous internal documents, including inspection records, engineering design files for various plant facilities, minutes of meetings, and correspondence between Reliance Infrastructure and the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL) on project execution and construction-related matters.

While *The Indian Express* could not independently verify the authenticity of these



The leaked dataset is largely related to Units 3 and 4 of the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant. REUTERS

documents, a spokesperson of Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group told this newspaper that there had been a “partial breach” of its data on a server hosted by third-party data

centre service provider Yotta, and the government had been informed about the incident.

In a statement to *Reuters*, Yotta also maintained that it had noted suspicious activity

on May 29 on a server it hosts that belongs to Reliance Infrastructure. It said the activity was immediately terminated and the suspected ransomware execution was prevented.

Following reports of data breach, state-owned NPCIL, the plant's operator, also clarified that the leaked information does not pertain to any nuclear safety or security systems and the compromised data relates only to the plant's conventional Balance of Plant common service facilities, for which Reliance Infrastructure Ltd was awarded a contract in 2018.

Located in Tirunelveli district of Tamil Nadu, Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant consists of six units of Pressurised Water Reactors of VVER design, which were established in technical collaboration

with Russia.

The first two units (KKNPP Units-1 & 2) are already in operation, while Units 3 and 4 are still under construction and are due to be operational by 2027. The remaining two units are at different stages of progress.

The leaked dataset is largely related to Units 3 and 4 of the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant and contains documents associated with the EPC contract executed by Reliance Infrastructure Ltd.

From tender documents and invoices to engineering drawings and design files for various structures, the folders appear to be organised according to different aspects of the project.

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